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The Sino-American World Conflict

Peter Rudolf

In Beijing a new consensus has emerged: that, in the words of Yonsei University professor Xiangfeng Yang, 'a shift in the tectonic plates of China's relations with the United States is afoot, or indeed already complete'.[1] Chinese officials had noted the Trump administration's stated determination to undertake a 'fundamental restructuring' of the relationship with China and to adopt a 'whole-of government approach' to managing US–Chinese competition.[2] President Joe Biden's China policy may be less confrontational and more nuanced than his predecessor's, but Secretary of State Antony Blinken has stated that although 'extreme competition', a phrase used by Biden,[3] does not exclude engagement with China, any such engagement will need to take place 'from a position of strength'.[4] Meanwhile, the dominant view in China seems to be that its strategic rivalry with the US will be intense and long-lasting.[5] It is widely expected that the United States, as the world's most powerful country, will use its resources to preserve its status and privileges, and to prevent China from rising further.[6] The coronavirus pandemic has only worsened the deterioration of US–China relations.[7]

The danger for international politics is that the intensifying strategic rivalry between the two states threatens to harden into what might be called a 'structural world conflict', with the attendant economic and military risks.[8] In this sense, talk of a 'new cold war' is not entirely misplaced,

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despite the problems and limitations of the analogy. In the United States, China's rise is widely seen as a threat to America's pre-eminent international position. The expectation among elites and the public alike is that China will threaten traditional US predominance not only in the Western Pacific and East Asia, but also globally.[9] Perceptions of China's 'unstoppable' economic and military rise, and of a relative decline in US power, may be based on questionable assumptions and projections.[10] However, China can arguably be described as an 'emerging potential superpower', a status with implications both for the United States and its allies, and for the international order more generally.[11]

Debating the Thucydides Trap

History shows that integrating a rising power into the international system is not an easy task.[12] Power-transition theory holds that even states without an aggressive, revisionist or risk-prone foreign policy tend to come into conflict with other powers as they attempt to secure raw materials, markets and military bases.[13] Thus, power shifts pose a considerable risk to the stability of the international system. This is sometimes known as 'Thucydides Trap', following Thucydides' interpretation of the Peloponnesian War as an inevitable result of the rising power of Athens, which forced a fearful Sparta to go to war.[14] The idea has been widely debated in both the United States and China.

Discussion about the Thucydides Trap in both countries testifies to an awareness of the risks associated with China's rise. Top Chinese officials, including President Xi Jinping himself, have repeatedly declared their intention to avoid the trap.[15] Sensitivity to the risks resulting from China's rise has been reflected in talk of seeking a 'new type of great power relationship' between the United States and China.[16]

The power-transition theories underpinning this discussion are not without their problems, however. Above all, it is important to note that such theories, by acting as frames that influence perceptions, are political constructs.[17] Frames contextualise facts and structure the flow of events. They serve to define problems and to diagnose their causes. They provide criteria for assessing developments, offer solutions and set the boundaries of debate. In this way, they contribute to the construction of political reality.[18]

Within the power-transition frame, conflicts that might otherwise be seen as regional or local in character gain such salience that they add up to a global hegemonic rivalry. To the extent that Chinese policies nourish and strengthen this perception in the United States, this might lead to a kind of self-fulfilling prophecy. At the very least, this frame can have a conflict-hardening effect resulting from the built-in expectation that a rising power will inevitably question the existing international order.[19] From this perspective, China is by definition a revisionist power.

If one takes official documents and statements as a yardstick, the prevailing perception in the United States is that China is thoroughly revisionist. Any hope that China's integration into international institutions and the global economy would make it a reliable partner has given way to the view that China – as well as Russia – is aiming to shape 'a world antithetical to U.S. values and interests'.[20] The 2017 US National Security Strategy states that both powers 'are contesting [the United States'] geopolitical advantages and trying to change the international order in their favor'.[21] According to the Pentagon, China 'seeks Indo-Pacific regional hegemony in the near-term and, ultimately global preeminence in the long-term'.[22] As then-secretary of state Mike Pompeo put it in 2019, 'China wants to be the dominant economic and military power of the world, spreading its authoritarian vision for society and its corrupt practices worldwide'.[23] As these statements indicate, the Trump administration based its China policy on worst-case assumptions about the long-term intentions of China's leadership.[24]

The Trump White House saw the relationship with China through the lens of a zero-sum logic, resolutely propagating the narrative of great-power competition and thereby shaping the China debate in the unique way that only authoritative speakers such as presidents and members of their administrations can do.[25] Narratives present an interpretation of the past ('the cooperative China policy has failed'), they interpret the current situation ('China is disputing US supremacy') and they offer strategic instruction for future action ('offensively compete using every available resource').[26]

While the revisionist label may serve a range of domestic and foreign-policy purposes in the United States, it does not necessarily provide an accurate picture of Chinese behaviour.[27] Indeed, China is not fundamentally

questioning the existing international order. This order consists of many principles, norms and functional regimes. China supports some of them and rejects others.[28] The term 'revisionist stakeholder' is a more precise way of describing the Chinese position: China operates within the framework of existing international organisations, especially the United Nations system, and insists on a traditional understanding of state sovereignty. However, it rejects US and Western dominance in international institutions and is dissatisfied with its own status. From the Chinese perspective, this status no longer corresponds to the country's increased power and the relative decline of the United States.[29]

Within Chinese discourse, the US narrative of great-power competition has been criticised as reflecting a Cold War, zero-sum mentality.[30] The Chinese government denies striving for hegemony or establishing spheres of influence. Beijing insists it will not follow the path taken by other rising powers.[31] President Xi's vision is for a rejuvenated China to become an economic, technological and cultural world power that exerts greater influence over the rules of international politics.[32] In this way, he has linked the Communist Party's claim to legitimacy with China's emergence as a leading world power.[33]

A new cold war?

A Cold War analogy is often used to interpret current conflicts in US–China relations, if only to highlight the differences between the Sino-American and the US–Soviet conflicts.[34] Indeed, some elements of American–Chinese relations lend themselves well to a comparison with the East–West conflict, such as the presence of an emerging bipolarity and ideological antagonism; a security dilemma and arms competition; and global power rivalry.[35] Like any analogy, however, Cold War comparisons are problematic and of limited use.

Status competition

The US–Chinese conflict encompasses regional and global competition for status in an international system characterised by an emerging bipolarity, even though there is no parity of power between America and China.[36] This is comparable to the Cold War era, during which the international order

was generally regarded as bipolar even though power resources were by no means equally distributed between the United States and the Soviet Union. Because the gap between these two states and the remaining powers was considerable, they were both regarded as superpowers.

In contrast to the Cold War, however, the relationship between the United States and China is not a confrontation between two mutually exclusive, opposing blocs, but a competition for influence within a globalised international system in which the two powers are highly intertwined economically.[37] In 2018, China was America's number-one trading partner – the third-largest export market for American products and the main source of the country's imports. For China, the United States tops the list of buyers of Chinese products.[38] There is also a high degree of industrial interdependence between the two economies, which has developed since the early 1990s as a result of an almost revolutionary change in the organisation of industrial production.[39] Today, components manufactured in China are used in many US products. Mutual dependencies have also arisen because China had long held the largest share of US treasury bonds until Japan overtook it in July 2019.[40]

China's actual and projected increase in power has aroused anxiety in the United States that it might lose its status as the predominant international superpower. States (or more precisely, the officials representing them) may aspire to high status as an end in itself: a high status creates the satisfying feeling of superiority over other people or states, while the prospect of losing one's status can threaten one's identity. But status is also associated with material gains. In the long run, China threatens not only the status of the United States as the lone superpower, but also its privileges and economic advantages.[41] If China were to become the world's predominant political, economic and technological power, it could, as the US fears, widely set rules and standards, and establish a kind of illiberal sphere of influence. If this were to happen, American security and prosperity would no longer be as secure as before.[42] The fear is that the US dollar would no longer dominate as the international reserve currency, and that the US would no longer attract the financial inflows that help secure American prosperity. Under these conditions, the United States would see its freedom of action curtailed.[43]

Ideological differences

It may be that, were China a liberal democracy, its rise would appear less threatening to the US. Since it is not a liberal democracy, the competition between China and the US contains an element of ideological antagonism. Unlike in the case of the East–West confrontation, however, this is not the core feature of the US–Chinese rivalry. During the Cold War, Soviet ideology completely ruled out any permanent coexistence with the capitalist system led by the United States, and the supposedly inevitable victory of communism worldwide was seen as guaranteeing the security of the Soviet Union. This element is missing in the Sino-American conflict. China's stance is better described as 'nationalist' rather than 'internationalist'.[44]

It is true that the human-rights situation in China has long been a source of friction in Sino-American relations, but as long as China's rise was not perceived as a global challenge, and as long as there was hope that China would liberalise, the country was not seen in the United States as an ideological antagonist. From the Chinese perspective, the ideological dimension has always been more pronounced, since Western ideas of liberal democracy and freedom of expression threaten the ideological dominance of the Communist Party.[45]

Recent debates in the United States, however, suggest that Americans have begun to perceive the ideological conflict between the American and Chinese systems as being of a similar dimension to that between Western democracy and Soviet communism. It has been argued that China's economically successful 'authoritarian capitalism' could find international resonance at a time when confidence in the systemic superiority of 'democratic capitalism' is weakening. In this scenario, competition for geopolitical power is mixed with a struggle for ideological superiority.[46]

China has even been portrayed as an existential threat both to the United States and to the world order.[47] The Trump administration, for example, characterised the conflict with China as an ideological clash between 'civilizations'.[48] China was accused of trying to 'reorder the world' by constructing 'a worldwide socialist order with Beijing at the center'.[49] This view plays down the fact that China lacks a 'coherent ideology with international appeal', as Cornell professor Jessica Chen Weiss has argued,[50] and that

Chinese policies are not aimed at establishing clientelist relationships with countries that share its own ideological orientation, as the Soviet Union once did.[51] The Chinese leadership under Xi may promote a development model that implicitly calls into question liberal democracy as a political ideal, and China's model of governance may be attractive for authoritarian states.[52] However, China's economic success is based on specific preconditions, including a large domestic market, an abundance of labour, the government's willingness to experiment and a spirit of pragmatic improvisation. Yes, China supports many authoritarian regimes, exports surveillance technology and exerts pressure on critical voices abroad. But this does not add up to a struggle against democracy or a strategy to undermine democratic systems.[53] Nevertheless, it is likely that a narrative of systemic conflict between 'digital authoritarianism' and 'liberal democracy' will become predominant in the US discourse, since it might help to mobilise long-term domestic political support for a costly competitive policy towards China.[54]

Security dilemma

Although the ideological element in the Sino-American rivalry is not its dominant feature, an increasing emphasis on the ideological differences between the two sides can be expected to influence their threat perceptions, thus reinforcing the security dilemma between them.[55] In an anarchic international system, no state can be certain that it will not be attacked, dominated or even extinguished. Measures to strengthen one's own security, however, whether through arms, territorial expansion or alliances, can reduce the security of other states, and thus lead to a competition for weaponry and power.[56] In its classical form, a security dilemma arises when offensive military doctrines and capabilities pose a threat to a state's territorial integrity, either in the form of an invasion or a nuclear first strike. In the context of the US–China rivalry, the United States has not accepted mutual nuclear vulnerability as the basis of its strategic relationship.[57] This could, it is feared, be understood as a lack of American resolve to defend its allies and interests in Asia. Moreover, Beijing would probably not be convinced by any US statements that it does not have plans to eliminate China's nuclear capability in the case of an escalating crisis.[58] Similarly, China does not trust American

assurances that the development of missile-defence systems is not directed against China's strategic nuclear potential.[59]

China has rejected the first use of nuclear weapons in its declaratory nuclear doctrine; it relies on a minimum-deterrence strategy and thus on the ability to retaliate.[60] Beijing fears that Washington's development of reconnaissance, surveillance and conventional prompt global-strike capabilities, as well as missile-defence systems, could jeopardise China's second-strike capability. China maintains a relatively small nuclear arsenal of an estimated 290 warheads.[61] However, there are plans to expand this arsenal by acquiring a greater number of missiles with multiple warheads. The United States is faced with the question of whether to accept its nuclear vulnerability in relation to China, which may result from the deployment of mobile intercontinental and sea-based ballistic missiles, or to pursue a damage-limitation strategy that at least opens up the possibility of limiting its own losses should deterrence fail. In accordance with the traditional logic of American deterrence policy, the US would need options for pre-emptively eliminating the enemy's nuclear arsenal.[62]

According to fears voiced in the US debate, a secure Chinese second-strike capability could lead to a greater Chinese willingness to take risks in crises. In the debate on nuclear strategy, this is referred to as the 'stability–instability paradox'.[63] This means that stability at the strategic level could tempt one side to use limited force in the expectation that the other will shy away from a massive nuclear strike, as this would lead to mutual destruction. According to this scenario, a secure Chinese second-strike capability threatens to raise doubts among America's Asian allies about the credibility of extended deterrence. If the United States follows the traditional line of its operational deterrence strategy by pursuing pre-emptive damage-limiting 'counterforce' options as a prerequisite for credible extended deterrence, the result will probably be an intensified arms competition.[64] The US nuclear posture, which is geared to limiting damage in the event of war, must be perceived as threatening by China – irrespective of the defensive motives of the American side.

In Sino-American relations a security dilemma is also present in the Taiwan question. This unresolved conflict over the sovereignty of Taiwan

carries the risk of war.[65] The Chinese leadership expressly reserves the right to use military force to prevent Taiwan's complete independence, as President Xi reiterated in January 2019.[66] Once it had normalised relations with the People's Republic of China in 1978, the United States ended official diplomatic ties with Taiwan and terminated the defence treaty between them. However, the Taiwan Relations Act of 1979 states that it is US policy to regard any attempt to decide Taiwan's future other than by peaceful means as a threat to peace and security in the Western Pacific. Consequently, the US policy is one of 'strategic ambiguity'; although Washington has promised to respond to any threat to Taiwan, it is not formally committed to doing so. For China, the goal of preventing Taiwan's lasting independence from mainland China is a defensive one. Beijing wants to militarily deter Taiwan from changing the status quo and declaring independence. However, Chinese military options might be perceived in an offensive sense, as enabling Beijing to compel reunification. The United States sees its security assurance to Taiwan, and the weapons systems it supplies to prevent an invasion by the People's Republic, as defensively motivated. Nevertheless, Washington's arming of Taiwan and maintaining of its own ability to intervene in a crisis might be perceived by Beijing as a protective umbrella enabling Taiwan to declare independence.[67]

The US policy is one of 'strategic ambiguity'

China sees the development of its own anti-access/area-denial capabilities in the South and East China seas as necessary to safeguard its core interests, which include preventing Taiwan from declaring independence. China may see this development as defensively motivated, but it is perceived in the United States as aimed at developing offensive capabilities which could make US power projection in the region more difficult and risky.[68]

Breaking out of a security dilemma is rarely easy. In order to assure an opponent of one's own defensive intentions, steps are needed that may be considered too risky – certainly if the opponent's present or future intentions are perceived as offensive.[69] Security dilemmas between states can be mitigated by mutual transparency, confidence-building measures and arms control.[70] However, in the case of Sino-American relations, each side

continues to insist that its intentions are purely defensive. Officially, China sees itself as a power that is retaking its position as a respected nation after a century of humiliation. Chinese history is interpreted as demonstrating that the country is peacefully minded, non-aggressive and non-expansive, whose rise has been hindered by the United States.[71] The US sees itself as a liberal democracy that does not pose a threat to other states and whose superior military strength serves the interests of all well-meaning people by guaranteeing international stability.[72] The danger is that each side's tendency to see itself as defensive and peaceful while attributing offensive and aggressive intentions to the other side will trigger a conflict spiral.[73]

Dissecting the strategic rivalry

The US–Chinese relationship is perhaps best interpreted as a complex 'strategic rivalry'. Both countries are not only competitors for power and influence, but also potential military opponents.[74] Their intensifying strategic rivalry, rooted in incompatible goals and mutual threat perceptions, has a regional dimension, a global dimension and a technological dimension.

The regional dimension

China has been expanding its military options to counter US intervention capabilities on its periphery and to project its own military power into the East Asian region and beyond. In conjunction with increased economic influence, this might enable China to 'decouple' the United States from Asia and thereby to gain supremacy in the region.[75] The US–China conflict is especially pronounced in the Western Pacific.[76] In 'maritime Asia', the relationship is antagonistic, imbued with military threat perceptions.[77] In the United States, it is widely believed that China intends to establish an exclusive 'maritime sphere of influence' in the South China Sea.[78]

In Chinese discourse, the prevailing self-perception seems to be that China does not intend to exclude non-regional actors from the region as is often assumed in the United States. Chinese behaviour in the South China Sea, however, can be taken as an indication that China is moving towards a policy of exclusion. Beijing has resolutely asserted legally questionable territorial claims and established military outposts on artificial islands.[79] In the

South China Sea, China's claims to some islands, rocks, reefs and low-tide elevations clash with those of four other littoral states (Brunei, Malaysia, the Philippines and Vietnam). In addition, China's sovereignty claims within what it calls the 'nine-dash line' (an area encompassing most of the South China Sea) conflict with the exclusive economic zones of these states and Indonesia. Moreover, China's interpretation of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (an interpretation that is shared by some other governments) is that states have the right to regulate and prohibit the military activities of other states in their exclusive economic zones, which extend up to 200 nautical miles from the coast. The United States firmly rejects this interpretation.[80]

The South China Sea is where the two sides' incompatible interpretations of the law of the sea are most apparent.[81] The US claims to be upholding the freedom of the seas, while the Chinese have been asserting a claim to a sphere of influence. The conflict is heightened by the mutual perception that in a crisis the other side could block important maritime lines of communication. If China were to block them, the economic costs would probably be bearable if shipping traffic to Australia, Japan and South Korea could be diverted, for example via the Sunda or Lombok straits. However, a large proportion of the goods shipped across the South China Sea come from China or go there. It is therefore in China's interest to ensure maritime transport remains unhindered in the region. The Chinese fear that the US military could block the Strait of Malacca in the event of a crisis, thus severely affecting China's energy supply.[82]

The geopolitical conflict over the South China Sea also has a nuclear dimension.[83] China seems to be fortifying the South China Sea as a protected bastion for ballistic-missile submarines as part of a survivable second-strike capability. According to information from the United States, at least four ballistic-missile submarines are already in service, and construction of a follow-on class, with a more advanced design, is expected to begin in the early 2020s.[84] China still has no sea-based ballistic missiles in service that could reach the continental United States from the South China Sea. The new missile (JL-3) in development for the planned next generation of submarines will have a significantly greater range than the current design, but even this

may not be enough.[85] Due to the limited range of the sea-based nuclear missiles currently in service, in the event of a serious international crisis, China may try to relocate ballistic-missile submarines to the deeper and thus safer waters of the Pacific, through the bottlenecks of the 'first island chain' (which extends from the Kuril Islands via the principal Japanese islands and Taiwan to Borneo). Securing the South China Sea against US anti-submarine forces is already an enormous challenge, a consideration that is relevant to China's expansion of its artificial islands.[86]

While the East–West conflict was stabilised to a significant degree by the establishment of clear spheres of influence in Europe, the geostrategic situation in East Asia is less stable. There is no clear demarcation between spheres of influence in Asia, and there are no acknowledged buffer zones. China's efforts to establish a kind of security zone within the first island chain are regarded as highly provocative in the United States as the region's leading sea power.[87]

A worsening crisis between the United States and China poses a considerable risk of military instability in Asia. US military planners assume that China will pursue offensive pre-emptive options in a crisis. Certainly, there are significant incentives for pre-emptive action against US armed forces in the region – for example, in the form of massive missile salvoes. Since the termination of the Intermediate-range Nuclear Forces Treaty, Washington has been free to deploy medium-range systems in Asia. These could be based on the island of Guam, or – should America's allies agree – in the north of Japan, the southern Philippines or the northern part of Australia. With conventionally equipped medium-range systems, the US military could destroy Chinese forces in the South and East China seas without sending naval units into these risk zones. This would also obviate the need to initially eliminate missile systems on the Chinese mainland that would endanger US surface ships. Such an attack could inadvertently neutralise Chinese nuclear forces or their command-and-control facilities since, according to available information, China's conventional and nuclear forces seem to be entangled. It cannot be ruled out that, in the event of a serious confrontation, China will be tempted to use nuclear weapons before they are put out of action.[88]

The global dimension

The Trump administration believed that any gains in influence by China would come at the expense of the United States. In particular, China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) was viewed with suspicion. The BRI and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) have allowed China to open new markets as outlets for its industrial overcapacities; to build road and rail networks to reduce its dependence on vulnerable sea lanes; and to widen its economic leverage and shore up its position in the global power competition.[89]

The Trump administration pushed the idea of a 'Free and Open Indo-Pacific' as a kind of counter-narrative to the BRI. The idea has been rightly characterised as a 'strategic narrative' that promotes American interests.[90] Like all narratives, it is intended to reduce complexity and mobilise domestic and international support. At the international level, the narrative contrasts a rules-based international order with an order shaped by China; at the national level, it signals the antithesis of democracy and autocracy; and at the thematic level, it highlights the difference between a defensive policy aimed at maintaining the status quo and an expansive, revisionist one.

The United States is trying to dissuade other countries from further developing economic ties with China. Washington has warned Israel against participating in infrastructure projects with China. Particularly worrisome is the prospect that the state-owned Shanghai International Port Group will operate the port of Haifa.[91] Similarly, during his visit to Panama in 2018, Pompeo warned the country's president against expanding economic relations with China. Washington is apparently concerned that Panama could become a 'bridgehead' for China's growing economic influence in the western hemisphere. China, whose ships are heavily reliant on the Panama Canal, is already involved in several infrastructure projects in Panama.[92]

Africa is regarded as the new front in the Sino-American struggle for influence. The Trump administration believed that Beijing was trying to make African countries submissive to Chinese interests through loans, bribery and dubious agreements. Introducing the United States' 'new Africa strategy' in December 2018, then-national security advisor John Bolton warned against China's 'predatory' practices in Africa.[93] Shortly before

leaving office, UN ambassador Nikki Haley tried to prevent a Chinese diplomat from being appointed UN Special Ambassador for the Great Lakes region in Africa. There may have been some concern that a Chinese ambassador could use this role to expand China's influence in the region. There is also more general concern about China's growing clout within the UN; China has been seeking to place its own diplomats in UN leadership positions. In addition, Beijing has considerably expanded its participation in UN peace missions, both financially and in terms of personnel. These developments have prompted the United States to scrutinise Chinese influence in the UN and other international organisations.[94]

Washington also sees the Arctic as an arena for great-power rivalry. China has displayed a growing interest in the region, releasing its own Arctic policy in January 2018. Not only does the Northern Sea Route shorten the distance between China and Europe considerably, but China is also interested in exploiting Arctic energy resources.[95]

The United States views China's presence in the Arctic as a potential security threat. In its 2019 report on Chinese military power, the US Department of Defense warned against China's growing presence in the region, including the possibility that China could deploy submarines there.[96] The Pentagon's report on its Arctic strategy published in June 2019 describes the region as a 'potential vector for an attack on the U.S. homeland'.[97] The deployment of ballistic-missile submarines in the Arctic would have two advantages for China. Firstly, if Chinese strategic submarines were able to operate under the ice, this would probably reduce their vulnerability to American anti-submarine warfare. Secondly, the flight times to targets in the continental United States are considerably shorter from the Arctic than from the Western Pacific. However, these scenarios are not likely to occur in the short term, in part because Chinese submarines would likely require a developed infrastructure in Arctic Russia.[98] Nevertheless, US military planners appear to be incorporating Arctic scenarios into their worst-case assumptions. Although China's White Paper on Arctic policy does not explicitly mention military aspects, the strategic importance of the Arctic is an important topic in Chinese military discourse.[99]

The technological dimension

The Sino-American conflict has a pronounced technological dimension as each side struggles for technological supremacy in the digital age. America wants to maintain its technological superiority over China, which is favourably positioned to benefit from the 'fourth industrial revolution', in which artificial intelligence plays an important role.[100] Competition for technological leadership is so pronounced because the introduction of new technologies creates economic growth and secures competitive advantages with military implications.[101] Many Americans now view China as a serious threat to the industrial foundations of the United States, and therefore as a threat to national security.[102] For the Chinese leadership, which believes that the technological superiority of the West has secured its global dominance, catching up and even surpassing the West in the field of advanced technology is a key priority.[103] It aims to do so through industrial-policy initiatives within the Made in China 2025 framework, technology transfer and industrial espionage.

The technological component of the US–China rivalry differs considerably from the United States' arms race with the Soviet Union. During the Cold War, the United States faced a technologically backward opponent, and was therefore able to shift military competition to areas where the Soviet Union was weak. With China, the United States faces an opponent against whom this option does not exist, since China has caught up technologically and is even leading in some areas, such as quantum computing and robotics. Maintaining or restoring technological leadership is thus of eminent military importance for the United States.[104]

The Trump administration undertook several initiatives aimed at impeding China's technological progress and protecting the United States' technological base. The Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States began to examine Chinese investments in the United States more closely, and even to restrict them. The Foreign Investment Risk Review Modernization Act of 2018 extended the scope of the review to include 'critical technology'.[105] The Export Control Reform Act, which came into force in August 2018, authorises export restrictions on 'emerging and foundational' technologies that are considered essential for US national security but are

not subject to existing controls. Among the technologies that the Bureau of Industry and Security within the US Department of Commerce (which is responsible for administering and enforcing the restrictions) has in mind are those that are central to Made in China 2025, including biotech, artificial intelligence and quantum computing.[106] There are also efforts under way to reduce the transfer of knowledge to China by Chinese students and scientists resident in the United States.

By decoupling the two economies as much as possible, the White House hoped to reduce US economic, technological and security vulnerabilities created by the countries' interdependence. (The pandemic appears only to have hastened these efforts.) Perhaps the most high-profile initiative was the Trump administration's campaign against Huawei, one of China's most important technology groups. For the 'China hawks' within the administration – particularly Peter Navarro, a presidential advisor on trade issues and director of the Office of Trade and Manufacturing Policy – the fight against Huawei was an important stage in the competition for future technological supremacy and control of information systems employing 5G networks.[107] Washington has especially sought to restrict Huawei's access to cutting-edge semiconductors, thereby focusing on an area where Chinese firms are heavily dependent on foreign suppliers.[108]

The campaign against Huawei reflects the abandonment of the positive-sum logic in economic relations. This logic, which was based on absolute gains, was linked to the expectation that economic interdependence would promote political cooperation. Now that China is seen as a global strategic rival, economic logic has given way to a security-policy logic, the dominant concern of which is the relative distribution of gains and the negative consequences of economic interdependence for preserving the technological basis of military superiority.[109]

The defensive and offensive measures adopted by the US will likely lead China to seek to reduce its own dependence on the United States and any other countries that might partner with the US in denying China access to advanced technology. As James Crabtree has written, Donald Trump's 'erratic and aggressive policies have succeeded in convincing Chinese elites that the U.S. is now irrevocably set on blocking China's technological rise'.[110]

Beijing's response, combined with US actions, could lead to the emergence of a new 'geoeconomic world order', in which the question of the relative distribution of gains, and concerns about the security consequences of economic interdependence, play a far more important role in determining government policy than in recent decades.[111] It is possible that as the economic interdependence between the United States and China dissolves, the world will experience de-globalisation and the emergence of economic blocs or closed economic spaces.[112]

The Sino-American world conflict could even trigger the emergence of two 'bounded orders', one led by the United States and the other by China.[113] This kind of bipolarisation would present dilemmas for American allies that favour a multipolar world order.[114]

* * *

Martin Wolf has suggested that the United States' strategic rivalry with China has the potential to develop into the 'organising principle of US economic, foreign and security policies'.[115] Certainly, there is ample reason to believe that Washington increasingly perceives all of its international relationships through a 'China prism', including its relationship with Europe.[116] The Biden administration can be expected to increase the pressure on US allies to take a stand in the intensifying Sino-American conflict and to join with the United States in balancing against China by restricting Chinese access to advanced technologies and screening Chinese foreign investments.[117]

From a European perspective, it is an open and vexing question whether Washington will rely on the power of persuasion or resort to economic pressure by means of its extraterritorial sanction levers to obtain European cooperation. US and European interests with regard to China are by no means identical, although European perceptions of China primarily as a source of economic opportunities have been giving way to a more nuanced view. A European Commission paper from March 2019 reflects this shift, referring to China as a 'cooperation partner', an 'economic competitor' and a 'systemic rival promoting alternative models of governance' depending on the policy field.[118] Even so, China's rise affects the United States and Europe to

different degrees, so their threat perceptions will continue to diverge. There is neither a status conflict nor a global competition for influence between Europe and China. Moreover, no security dilemmas are shaping the relationship, meaning that security concerns do not overshadow all aspects of the relationship. The coronavirus pandemic has led to some discussion of how much dependence on China is tolerable, but only with respect to a diversification of supply chains and production sites, rather than in the sense of a broad decoupling.[119]

Given partly converging, partly diverging interests on each side of the Atlantic, as well as within the European Union, there is a widespread sense that transatlantic policy coordination on China will have to become an institutionalised feature in US–EU relations, whether in the guise of the US–European Dialogue on China initiated in 2020 by Josep Borrell, the EU high representative for foreign affairs and security policy, or in more functional formats occasionally suggested in the US debate and apparently taken up by the Biden administration in its evolving 'modular approach' to restricting Chinese access to advanced technology.[120] Certainly, European allies are faced with the question of how far and under which conditions they will support the United States in its strategic rivalry with China.

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Notes

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